6Wunderkinder: Wunderkit or Wunderlist?

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MODULE 07 · THE KILL DECISION · CASE, READ BEFORE CLASS

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In the summer of 2012, Christian Reber, founder and chief executive of 6Wunderkinder GmbH in Berlin, ran a team of 36 people and two products.[1] [2] Wunderkit, a platform for organising work and private projects in one place, had opened to the public on 1 February 2012, by Reber's account after about a year of development.[3] [4] Almost 400,000 people had signed up for it "within the last six months", the company wrote in September 2012.[5] Engagement, the company reported, did not meet its expectations, and the team had worked on a redesign for months without reaching a result it was satisfied with.[5]

Wunderlist, a to-do app the company had built first as what it called "a little appetizer", had reached 2 million users in February 2012.[5] [6] In June the technology site GigaOM counted "around three million users" across the two products.[7]

Wunderkit was the product 6Wunderkinder had been founded to build.[5] Reber described the choice the team faced in one sentence, "Either we focus on Wunderkit or Wunderlist – both would be too much of a challenge."[4] Exhibit 1 shows how the company got there.

An Appetizer and a Main Course

Reber founded 6Wunderkinder in Berlin in August 2010 with five friends as co-founders.[5] [2] Its mission was to create a product that would "reinvent project management". The company called it Wunderkit.[5] Knowing that it would take a long time to build, "we decided to start with a little appetizer to show everyone what we were capable of," the company wrote. The appetizer was Wunderlist, a task manager, launched in November 2010 on Mac and Windows.[5] [4]

In August 2012 Reber wrote on the company blog that the first version had been built "in only two and a half months", as "a testing bed" for what was to come.[2]

On 17 August 2011 the company announced one million users within 275 days, with 2.6 million downloads and 3,600 new registrations a day.[8] The app was free on every device, synced tasks to the cloud and let users "share your lists with friends and colleagues and collaborate on tasks". The company called it "our way of finding out what you guys really needed in productivity software".[8] It followed on iPhone, iPad, the web, Android, BlackBerry and Windows Phone.[5]

On 16 November 2011 Atomico, the London venture firm of the Skype co-founder Niklas Zennström, invested $4.2 million in 6Wunderkinder.[9] [10] The company wrote that the investment would accelerate product development "with a focus on Wunderkit", and that Wunderlist had by then helped "over 1.4 million people" organise their lives.[9]

Wunderkit, a Year in the Making

Wunderkit was meant to go further than a to-do list. The launch press release described “a state-of-the-art platform that contains a blend of a social network and online working space for the individual”, where users created workspaces, collaborated and followed status updates and tasks.[3] “We wanted to completely merge private and business projects,” the company wrote, with tasks, notes, projects, collaboration and comments in one place.[5]

Reber explained the idea with examples. Wunderkit would let a band keep its lyrics and organise its gigs, or let mothers organise their children’s homework alongside home and work. “We weren’t only focused on businesses,” he wrote, “because we knew that if we convince consumers, they would bring it into their workplace.”[4] [19] Before the launch, he recalled, “many of my close friends advised me to focus on Wunderlist and forget about Wunderkit, but for me it was the clear path for our company.”[4]

Wunderkit took longer than planned. On 9 January 2012 the company wrote that its target of a late-2011 release had been “slightly ambitious”. About 150 people were using a closed beta, and a public launch was planned for early February.[11] The same post said that “each and every one of us has been pouring 100% of our energy into Wunderkit”, and promised that “we certainly won’t be neglecting Wunderlist in favor of the new addition to the family.”[11] In February a post addressed to Wunderlist said, “When Wunderkit has a problem, we rush to his aid,” and promised to rebuild Wunderlist “from the ground up” over the coming year.[6] Reber wrote later in 2012 that “after several delays” the company had decided to focus only on Wunderkit, which meant pausing the development of Wunderlist.[4]

At the launch the technology site TechCrunch wrote that Wunderkit now competed directly with “full virtual workspace apps such as Podio or Asana”.[12]

Launch, and a Price Change in Two Weeks

The public beta opened on 1 February 2012 on the web, on iPhone and as a beta Mac app.[13] [3] The German blog BASIC thinking reported that more than 100,000 people had waited for an invite one day after the closed beta began, without naming its source.[14] Reber recalled that after one day Apple featured Wunderkit as “App of the Week” in several countries.[4]

At launch, free users could collaborate inside workspaces they owned and read the workspaces they joined. Adding or editing tasks and notes in other people’s workspaces required a Pro account at $4.99 a month, with a 90-day free trial (Exhibit 2).[15] [3] Some readers asked about the model in the comments on the launch post.[13] On 15 February the company announced a change. “Many of you voiced concerns about our initial pricing plan,” it wrote, and made collaboration “completely free for everybody on the planet”. Pro remained as an option for further extras.[16] [17] The next day the IT weekly Computerwoche wrote that after the first hype it had gone very quiet around the new platform.[18] The sources do not disclose how many users paid for Pro.

Six Months Later

In September 2012 Reber described what the team had seen after the launch. “While the launch of Wunderkit was again a success for us, after a month we saw clearly that there was something wrong with the product,” he wrote. Sign-ups were good, “but when it came to retention, organic growth and quality we weren’t doing as well.” During the first days the team also saw scaling issues and bugs, “caused mainly by the product’s complexity and the time pressure to release it”.[4] The company wrote

that “engagement was not meeting our expectations”, that users raised concerns about bugs, scaling and usability, and that the feedback pointed to one key issue, complexity.[5] It gave no figures for active users, retention, paying users or revenue.

The team redesigned Wunderkit. It focused on the main interface and on making projects simpler, Reber wrote.[4] “We worked for months (and months!) to come up with a beautiful simple approach that met our expectations, yet we simply couldn’t reach a point that we were satisfied with,” the company wrote. None of the new designs was released.[5] Meanwhile, by the company’s account, users and team grew increasingly frustrated with Wunderkit and with the lack of updates to Wunderlist.[5]

The company’s public posts of the summer described work in progress. On 4 July it wrote that the team had been busy “working away behind the scenes on our products, doing some fine-tuning with the backend, tinkering with features and without giving too much away, working on something completely new.” A postscript told Wunderkit users that “we are analyzing all the great beta feedback you have sent us and are right now working on pimping the backend for you.”[20] On 16 August, the company’s second birthday, Reber wrote of “6 co-founders to 36 Wunderkinder in just two years” and two products on 11 platforms. Of Wunderkit he wrote that “[t]he experience so far has been different to Wunderlist, but it is also a very different product.” The beta, he added, showed “a community of passionate users”, and the success of Wunderlist was “what allowed us to build Wunderkit”.[2] More than 20 of the 36 were engineers and five worked on product design.[4]

Meanwhile, Wunderlist

On 21 February 2012 the company announced that Wunderlist had reached 2 million users and handled “around 2.1 million tasks per week”, helping “hundreds of thousands of people organize themselves every day”.[6] In June it passed 100 million tasks and its one billionth sync.[20] On 16 August Reber wrote that it was “helping over 2.5 million people every day”.[2] The app was free in August 2011, and the sources describe no revenue model for it.[8] By the company’s and Reber’s later accounts, its development had been paused for Wunderkit and users missed updates.[5] [4] Exhibit 3 sets the two products’ numbers side by side.

Money on the Table

Atomico’s $4.2 million of November 2011 had come with the company’s statement that it would go “with a focus on Wunderkit”.[9] In late May 2012, as the magazine Manager Magazin reported according to GigaOM, the venture investor Earlybird bought the stake of the High-Tech Gründerfonds, an early public-private investor.[7] According to deutsche-startups.de, Earlybird also bought some shares held by e42, the investment company of Frank Thelen and Marc Sieberger.[10] According to GigaOM, the company registry showed Earlybird with 15.49 percent and Atomico with 19.6 percent (Exhibit 4).[7] GigaOM wrote that it “looks like” none of the money had gone to 6Wunderkinder itself.[7]

Earlybird’s partner told GigaOM that “Atomico and us together can provide significant double-digit financing volume, which is something that gives the team the confidence to continue focusing on the product,” and that “[w]e’re betting on them doing further amazing stuff with Wunderlist and Wunderkit, based on their product DNA.”[7] The sources do not disclose the company’s monthly costs or how long its cash would last.

Three Ways Forward

By the summer of 2012 the team had three ways forward. It could focus on Wunderkit, the product it was founded to build, which almost 400,000 people had signed up for and which the team had redesigned for months without a result it was satisfied with.[5] It could focus on Wunderlist, which Reber wrote was “helping over 2.5 million people every day” and for which the sources describe no revenue model.[2] [8] Or it could keep balancing both. Earlybird’s partner said in June that his firm was “betting on them doing further amazing stuff with Wunderlist and Wunderkit”.[7] Reber judged both “too much of a challenge”, and the company wrote that keeping both meant it would “risk both”.[4] [5]

The decision belonged to Reber and his team. Wunderkit, Wunderlist or both?

Exhibits

Exhibit 1: Timeline, August 2010 to August 2012

Date	Event
August 2010	6Wunderkinder founded in Berlin
November 2010	Wunderlist launched on Mac and Windows
17 August 2011	Wunderlist at one million users, 275 days after launch
16 November 2011	Atomico invests $4.2 million, “with a focus on Wunderkit”
9 January 2012	Wunderkit in closed beta with about 150 people, public launch planned for early February
1 February 2012	Wunderkit public beta on the web, iPhone and Mac
15 February 2012	Collaboration in Wunderkit made free for everyone
21 February 2012	Wunderlist at 2 million users
Late May 2012	Earlybird buys the High-Tech Gründerfonds stake, as reported
June 2012	Wunderlist passes 100 million tasks
4 July 2012	Company blog, “working on something completely new”, and for Wunderkit users “pimping the backend”
16 August 2012	Company’s second birthday, 36 people

Source: compiled by the case writer from the company blog, a press release and press reports, see notes [5], [8], [9], [11], [13], [16], [6], [7], [20] and [2].

Exhibit 2: Wunderkit pricing at launch and after 15 February 2012

	At launch, pricing page of 2 February 2012	After the change, page of 18 February 2012
Free account	Collaborate in workspaces you create. Read notes and tasks of workspaces you join. Unlimited workspaces. No ads	“Completely free for life”. Collaboration inside or outside your own workspace. Join an unlimited number of workspaces. Web, Mac and iPhone. No ads
Pro account, $4.99 a month	Unlimited collaboration inside any workspace, adding and editing in other people’s projects, priority support, a “Pro” badge, group billing	New built-in apps (“coming soon!”), priority support, a “Pro” badge, group billing
Trial	Wunderkit Pro free for 90 days	Wunderkit Pro free for 90 days

Source: Wunderkit pricing pages as captured by the Internet Archive on 2 and 18 February 2012, and the company’s post of 15 February 2012, which kept the Pro price at $4.99 a month, see notes [15], [17] and [16]. One German blog gave the Pro price as 3.99 euros, see note [17].

Exhibit 3: Two products in numbers, 2011 to 2012

Date	Wunderlist	Wunderkit
17 August 2011	1 million users, 2.6 million downloads, 3,600 new registrations a day	In development
16 November 2011	“Over 1.4 million people” helped	Promised “in the coming weeks”
9 January 2012		Closed beta, about 150 people
January 2012		More than 100,000 waiting for an invite, as BASIC thinking reported
31 January 2012	“Close to 2 million registered users”	Public beta the next day
21 February 2012	2 million users, about 2.1 million tasks a week	
June 2012	More than 100 million tasks in total	
18 June 2012	Around three million users across both products, by GigaOM’s count	(included in the GigaOM count)
16 August 2012	“Helping over 2.5 million people every day”	“A community of passionate users”
“Within the last six months”, reported 6 September 2012		Almost 400,000 sign-ups
Not disclosed	Revenue	Active users, retention, paying users, revenue

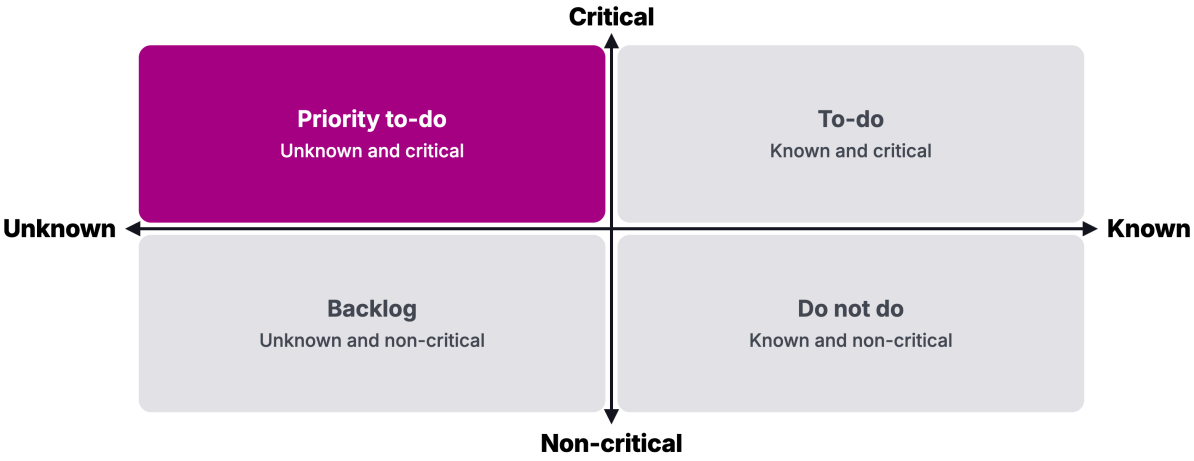
Source: compiled by the case writer from the company’s blog posts and press release and from press reports, in each source’s own terms (users, registered users, people helped, sign-ups), see notes [8], [9], [11], [14], [3], [6], [20], [7], [2] and [5].

Exhibit 4: Ownership of 6Wunderkinder after Earlybird’s purchase, 2012

Shareholder	Share	As reported by
Atomico	19.6 percent	GigaOM, from the company registry
Atomico	about 20 percent	deutsche-startups.de
Earlybird	15.49 percent	GigaOM, from the company registry
Earlybird	about 15 percent	deutsche-startups.de
e42	just under 12 percent	deutsche-startups.de
T-Venture	9 percent	deutsche-startups.de
Founders and others	not reported	

Source: deutsche-startups.de, 8 June 2012, and GigaOM, 18 June 2012, see notes [10] and [7]. T-Venture was the investment arm of Deutsche Telekom, e42 the investment company of Frank Thelen and Marc Sieberger. The shares do not add up to the whole company because the founders’ and other holdings were not reported.

The assumption map from the course



Assumptions sorted by how critical they are and how much is known.

Source: course graphic after legacy slide 749. It holds no data about 6Wunderkinder.

Endnotes

1. The date of the decision is not documented. The sources place it between May and August 2012. The company's public posts of 4 July and 16 August 2012 do not mention it. The case describes the situation as it stood in the summer of 2012.
2. Christian Reber, "Time to celebraaate! Happy Birthday 6Wunderkinder", 6Wunderkinder blog, 16 August 2012, Internet Archive capture of 13 September 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120913023136/http://www.6wunderkinder.com:80/blog/time-to-celebrate-happy-birthday-6wunderkinder, accessed 2026-10-19.
3. 6Wunderkinder, "6Wunderkinder Launches Public Beta of Project Management tool for Individuals and Groups", press release dated 31 January 2012, Internet Archive capture of 2 February 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120202053510/http://www.6wunderkinder.com/blog/2012/02/01/6wunderkinder-launches-public-beta-of-project-management-tool-for-individuals-and-groups/, accessed 2026-10-19.
4. Christian Reber, personal blog, post of 6 September 2012, as listed on his blog's home page, Internet Archive capture of 11 September 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120911012405/http://christianreber.com:80/, accessed 2026-10-19. The figure of more than 20 engineers and five people on product design, of 36, is from this post.
5. 6Wunderkinder, company blog, post of 6 September 2012, as listed on the blog's index page, Internet Archive capture of 8 September 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120908203646/http://www.6wunderkinder.com:80/blog, accessed 2026-10-19. The count of almost 400,000 sign-ups is the post's "within the last six months". The count on the day of the decision is not known.
6. 6Wunderkinder, "We love you, Wunderlist. And your 2 million users too!", company blog, 21 February 2012, Internet Archive capture of 20 August 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120820194551/http://www.6wunderkinder.com/blog/we-love-you-wunderlist-and-your-2-million-users-too, accessed 2026-10-19.
7. GigaOM Europe, "Revealed: Why 6wunderkinder's backers really sold up", 18 June 2012, http://gigaom.com/europe/mystery-resolved-6wunderkinder-htgf-earlybird/, accessed 2026-10-19 from a saved copy of the page. GigaOM named no source for the user count. It cited Manager Magazin for the sale in late May and the company registry for the shares.
8. 6Wunderkinder, "Holy cow, we're millionaires! (Well, in terms of users…)", company blog, 17 August 2011, Internet Archive capture of 19 August 2011, https://web.archive.org/web/20110819080939/http://www.6wunderkinder.com/blog/2011/08/17/holy-cow-were-millionaires-well-in-terms-of-users/, accessed 2026-10-19.
9. 6Wunderkinder, "Atomico invests $4,200,000 in 6Wunderkinder", company blog, 16 November 2011, Internet Archive capture of 17 November 2011, https://web.archive.org/web/20111117180915/http://www.6wunderkinder.com/blog/2011/11/16/atomico-invests-4200000-in-6wunderkinder/, accessed 2026-10-19.
10. deutsche-startups.de, "High Tech Gründerfonds steigt bei 6Wunderkinder aus – Earlybird steigt ein", 8 June 2012, https://www.deutsche-startups.de/2012/06/08/6wunderkinder-earlybird/, accessed 2026-10-19. The article gives Atomico's investment as 4.2 million dollars and names Niklas Zennström as head of Atomico.
11. 6Wunderkinder, "Wunderful things are in store for 2012", company blog, 9 January 2012, Internet Archive capture of 23 August 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120823002132/http://www.6wunderkinder.com/blog/wunderlist-and-wunderkit-our-2012-roadmap, accessed 2026-10-19.
12. TechCrunch, "Wunderkit launches beta for its wunderbar-designed productivity platform", 1 February 2012, https://techcrunch.com/2012/02/01/wunderkit-launches-beta-for-its-wunderbar-designed-productivity-platform-2/, accessed 2026-10-19.
13. 6Wunderkinder, "The Wunderkit beta goes public – welcome one and all!", company blog, 1 February 2012, with readers' comments, Internet Archive capture of 2 February 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120202053440/http://www.6wunderkinder.com/blog/2012/02/01/the-wunderkit-beta-goes-public-welcome-one-and-all/, accessed 2026-10-19.
14. BASIC thinking, "Wunderkit geht in die öffentliche Beta, startet Mac- und iPhone-App", 1 February 2012, https://www.basicthinking.de/blog/2012/02/01/wunderkit-geht-in-die-offentliche-beta-startet-mac-und-iphone-app/, accessed 2026-10-19.

15. Wunderkit, pricing page, Internet Archive capture of 2 February 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120202083525/http://get.wunderkit.com/pricing/, accessed 2026-10-19.
16. 6Wunderkinder, “From Berlin with love – Wunderkit is now free, forever”, company blog, 15 February 2012, Internet Archive capture of 16 February 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120216175718/http://www.6wunderkinder.com/blog/2012/02/15/from-berlin-with-love-wunderkit-is-now-free-forever/, accessed 2026-10-19.
17. Wunderkit, Pro page, Internet Archive capture of 18 February 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120218173717/http://get.wunderkit.com/pro/, accessed 2026-10-19. The company’s post of 15 February, Computerwoche and BASIC thinking’s launch report gave the price in dollars. BASIC thinking’s report of 15 February gave 3.99 euros a month, https://www.basicthinking.de/blog/2012/02/15/wunderkit-nach-kritik-jetzt-alle-basisfunktionen-kostenlos, accessed 2026-10-19.
18. Computerwoche, “6Wunderkinder rudert zurück: Wunderkit doch eher free als Freemium”, 16 February 2012, https://www.computerwoche.de/article/2646146/wunderkit-doch-eher-free-als-freemium.html, accessed 2026-10-19. The original reads „nach dem ersten Rummel ist es reichlich ruhig geworden um die neue Plattform“. Translated from German by the case writer.
19. The sources describe no test of this belief before the launch.
20. 6Wunderkinder, “Wunderlist reaches more than 100 million tasks”, company blog, 4 July 2012, Internet Archive capture of 27 August 2012, https://web.archive.org/web/20120827000058/http://www.6wunderkinder.com/blog/wunderlist-reaches-more-than-100-million-tasks-and-one-billion-syncs, accessed 2026-10-19. The post dates the milestones to “last month”.